The majority of Israelis supported the 'peace process'. They believed that it was worth exchanging land for security and accepted that, one day, there would have to be a Palestinian state based on the West Bank and Gaza. But, after a series of suicide bombings on crowded buses in Israeli towns, the hardliners in Israel gained more support. In May 1996, six months after the death of Rabin, a new government was elected in Israel. This government opposed the Oslo peace process and blocked any further negotiations with Arafat and the PA.

Building new Jewish settlements

Key question
What was the effect of new settlement building?

In February 1997 the new Israeli government gave the go-ahead for the building of 6500 new homes on Arab land in east Jerusalem. This would complete a chain of Jewish settlements round the eastern side of Jerusalem and effectively cut off the Arab inhabitants of east Jerusalem from the rest of the West Bank (see the map on page 104). This further dashed Palestinian hopes of making east Jerusalem the capital of an independent state of Palestine.

As the bulldozers went into action to clear the ground for building to start, the new Israeli Prime Minister, Binyamin Netanyahu, announced; 'The battle for Jerusalem has begun.' For most Palestinians, the Israeli Prime Minister was not a peace-maker but the leader of a brutal occupying power.



An Israeli bulldozer prepares to flatten an Arab house on the West Bank, February 1997, to make way for a larger Jewish settlement. What impact did settlement building have on the peace process?